

CALL TARGET

LIFE-2026-SAP-ENV-ENVIRONMENT — Circular Economy and Zero Pollution. Single-stage deadline: 22 September 2026, 17:00 CEST. Indicative project budgets: EUR 2–10 million. Maximum LIFE co-funding rate for SAPs: 60%.

IMPORTANT STATUS NOTE

This document separates (A) evidence already documented in the MyZubster dossier and official sources from (B) proposed project targets/roles that still require partner confirmation. No organisation listed below is treated as committed unless a written confirmation/Lol is obtained.

1. CONCEPT IN ONE PARAGRAPH

LIFE MyZubster proposes to demonstrate a circular-water and environmental-MRV system on the Cesena–Rimini axis by connecting a real wastewater-reuse flow with interoperable operational data, scientific validation and a Digital Environmental Passport. The physical demonstrator is anchored to the existing Cesena water-reuse context; MyZubster adds the digital layer for data provenance, cross-organisation interoperability, evidence hashing/references, automated MRV, dashboards and a replication kit. The objective is not to replace existing treatment or monitoring systems, but to make environmental performance end-to-end traceable, auditable and easier to replicate across utilities and territories.

2. DOCUMENTED BASELINE / EVIDENCE

- Hera reports an agreement with Regione Emilia-Romagna, Arpae, Atersir and Consorzio di Bonifica della Romagna concerning recovery/reuse of 6 million m³ of wastewater from the Cesena treatment plant. This is the strongest candidate anchor for the flagship pilot; the dossier does not establish that all 6 million m³ are already effectively reused each year.
- Hera reports 43.7 million m³ of treated wastewater reusable/reused in 2024 at Group level, equal to 11.9% of total treated wastewater, up from 2023.
- Romagna Acque publishes georeferenced delivery points with water-quality analyses and historical records from 2012, plus hydrological data for Ridracoli. This provides an existing digital baseline that can be integrated rather than duplicated.
- Comune di Rimini has documented experience as coordinator of LIFE-HELP, supporting its credibility as a possible public coordinating/territorial authority.
- The MyZubster dossier already defines a preliminary Digital Environmental Passport containing source/asset ID, timestamp, geolocation, source organisation, water flow/volume, quality parameters and method, reuse destination, provenance, validation status, KPI, supporting evidence/hash/reference and replication metadata.

3. PROBLEM TO SOLVE

Water reuse already involves physical assets, laboratory/SCADA data, public authorities, environmental reporting and regulatory controls, but the evidence is often fragmented across different organisations and systems. This limits the ability to demonstrate additionality, compare

baseline versus achieved impact, audit data lineage and transfer the same model to other territories. LIFE MyZubster addresses this verification/interoperability gap around an existing physical circular-water pathway.

4. LIFE ADDITIONALITY

The project must prove that LIFE financing adds something material beyond systems that already exist. The proposed additionality is:

- cross-organisation data interoperability between utility, water-source, public-authority and scientific datasets;
- end-to-end provenance and validation status for each relevant environmental record;
- automated MRV and a Digital Environmental Passport linked to the physical water flow;
- common QA/QC and uncertainty methodology developed with a scientific partner;
- operational dashboards for project management and LIFE indicators;
- a documented replication kit that can be adopted by at least two additional territories/utilities;
- a governance model defining public/private data, cybersecurity constraints, rights of reuse and aggregation/anonymisation.

5. PROPOSED OBJECTIVES

O1 — Establish a verified baseline for the Cesena–Rimini circular-water demonstrator using historical and operational data from participating organisations.

O2 — Integrate water-volume, quality, provenance and reuse-destination data into an interoperable MRV layer without replacing existing SCADA/laboratory systems.

O3 — Demonstrate a Digital Environmental Passport for water reuse with auditable evidence and validation status.

O4 — Quantify environmental benefits with scientifically validated LIFE KPIs, including verified reused-water volumes and substitution of primary-water demand where data permit.

O5 — Replicate the technical and governance model in at least two additional contexts, preferably including one transnational replication partner if feasible and material to project objectives.

O6 — Produce an exploitation/continuation plan so the system remains operational after LIFE funding.

6. PROPOSED KPI FRAMEWORK — TO VALIDATE WITH PILOT AND SCIENTIFIC PARTNERS

KPI 1 — Annual volume of water covered by verified MRV: initial design range 3–6 million m³/year at the flagship pilot; final target only after access to baseline and confirmation of actual reuse flows.

KPI 2 — Share of agreed pilot data streams with machine-readable provenance and validation status: target ≥90% by demonstration phase.

KPI 3 — Share of verified reuse events/periods represented by a Digital Environmental Passport: target ≥90% of the agreed monitoring perimeter.

KPI 4 — Reduction in manual effort needed to assemble auditable environmental evidence: provisional target 30–50%, to be baselined during WP2.

KPI 5 — Additional verified substitution of primary water attributable to project actions: target to be defined from partner baseline; no value is claimed at concept-note stage.

KPI 6 — Data-quality/QA-QC completeness for mandatory parameters: target $\geq 95\%$ within the agreed dataset perimeter.

KPI 7 — Replication: at least 2 signed replication commitments/use cases and 1 reusable implementation kit.

KPI 8 — Post-project continuation: at least 1 operational/financial continuation agreement for the core MRV/passport service.

7. PROPOSED WORK PACKAGES

WP1 — Project management, governance and LIFE reporting

Lead candidate: public coordinator (Comune di Rimini or another formally confirmed eligible beneficiary).

Outputs: governance, risk management, reporting, ethics/data governance, consortium coordination.

WP2 — Baseline, pilot design and permits/data agreements

Lead candidate: Hera / infrastructure operator with public-authority support.

Outputs: validated baseline, monitoring perimeter, data-sharing agreement, pilot protocol, cybersecurity/data-access rules.

WP3 — Digital MRV and Environmental Passport

Lead candidate: MyZubster.

Outputs: data model, APIs/connectors, provenance layer, dashboard, evidence references/hashes, passport schema, audit trail, replication-ready software package.

WP4 — Scientific validation, QA/QC and impact methodology

Lead candidate: ENEA / university / other confirmed scientific validator.

Outputs: MRV methodology, QA/QC, uncertainty treatment, KPI calculation protocol, LCA/LCSA where appropriate, independent validation reports.

WP5 — Demonstration and performance assessment

Lead candidate: pilot operator + scientific partner.

Outputs: operational demonstration, validated results, environmental performance, corrective actions, comparison with baseline.

WP6 — Replication, exploitation and policy uptake

Lead candidate: ART-ER / public authority / MyZubster, subject to consortium confirmation.

Outputs: replication kit, two replication cases, business/continuation model, policy recommendations, stakeholder uptake.

WP7 — Communication and dissemination

Lead candidate: coordinator with all partners.

Outputs: LIFE communication obligations, public dashboard where appropriate, stakeholder events, technical publications, replication outreach.

8. CONSORTIUM MATRIX — CURRENT TARGET

Partner / type | Proposed role | Why it matters | Current status | Immediate ask
Comune di Rimini / public authority | Candidate coordinator; territorial governance; replication/policy | Proven LIFE coordination experience in dossier | TARGET — not committed | Confirm interest, coordinator availability, PIC/administrative capacity, internal decision path
Hera / water utility | Flagship infrastructure/pilot; operational baseline; SCADA/lab data | Real Cesena reuse context and quantified public evidence | TARGET — not committed | Technical call; confirm pilot perimeter, actual reuse baseline, data access, co-financing
Romagna Acque / water-source operator | Source/baseline data integration; laboratory/R&D | Georeferenced quality history and Ridracoli data | TARGET — not committed | Confirm data-owner contact, permitted datasets/API, role as beneficiary/associated stakeholder
ENEA / R&I | Scientific/MRV/QA-QC and possible water-reuse validation | Strong technical fit with water reuse and monitoring | CONTACTED — response not yet treated as commitment | Convert discussion into defined WP4 tasks, person-months and budget
Scientific university partner | LCA/LCSA, methodology, validation | Needed to strengthen methodology and independent credibility | CANDIDATE | Confirm one accountable lead and deliverables; avoid duplicating ENEA role
ART-ER / regional innovation | Replication, innovation ecosystem, regional scaling | Strong bridge to Emilia-Romagna ecosystem | TARGET | Test interest; define replication/exploitation role and budget
MyZubster | Digital MRV, data provenance, Environmental Passport, replication software | Core digital contribution | PROMOTER | Produce technical architecture, effort estimate, ownership/IP and exploitation plan
EU replication partner(s) | Replication demonstration / transfer | Strengthens impact and potential transnational bonus if essential | TO IDENTIFY | Secure 1–2 Lols with concrete replication scope and baseline availability

9. PRELIMINARY BUDGET ENVELOPE — WORKING ASSUMPTION, NOT COMMITMENT

Recommended first planning scenario: EUR 3.8 million total eligible project cost over approximately 42 months.

Maximum LIFE contribution at 60%: EUR 2.28 million.

Indicative consortium co-financing: EUR 1.52 million.

Illustrative allocation by WP:

WP1 Management & governance — EUR 0.38m (10%)

WP2 Baseline/pilot/data agreements — EUR 0.57m (15%)

WP3 Digital MRV/passport — EUR 0.76m (20%)

WP4 Scientific validation/QA-QC/LCA — EUR 0.57m (15%)

WP5 Demonstration/performance — EUR 0.95m (25%)

WP6 Replication/exploitation/policy — EUR 0.38m (10%)

WP7 Communication — EUR 0.19m (5%)

This split is only a negotiation frame. Final costs must be rebuilt beneficiary-by-beneficiary from personnel, subcontracting, equipment/depreciation, travel and other eligible categories in the Funding & Tenders forms.

10. EVALUATION STRATEGY

The 2026 call scores Relevance, Impact, Quality and Resources. Each criterion must reach at least 10/20; Impact is weighted 1.5 and is therefore the most important place to invest effort.

Relevance — Anchor the project to Water Reuse Regulation 2020/741, integrated water management, wastewater treatment/resource recovery and the call priority on optimising existing infrastructure. Make clear that the environmental intervention is physical and operational, while MyZubster verifies and scales it.

Impact — Quantify baseline and target m³, primary-water substitution, quality compliance, resource/energy implications, post-LIFE operation and replicability. Avoid unsupported numbers.

Quality — Use a feasible work plan, named data owners, clear pilot geography, permits/data governance and risk controls. Demonstrate stakeholder mobilisation with Lols.

Resources — Match every beneficiary to an essential task and realistic budget; avoid overlapping scientific roles or a consortium larger than necessary.

Potential bonus strategy: a proposal that substantially builds on/up-scales results of other EU-funded projects may receive bonus points; transnational cooperation may also receive bonus points when essential to objectives. These should be used only if factually justified in the final proposal.

11. CRITICAL GAPS TO CLOSE

- 1) No formal partner commitments/Lols are yet recorded in the dossier.
- 2) Actual Cesena reused-water baseline versus theoretical/available 6m m³ must be confirmed.
- 3) The coordinator must be decided quickly.
- 4) Scientific validation ownership must be assigned to one accountable lead or a clearly non-overlapping team.
- 5) Data governance and access to operational datasets must be confirmed.
- 6) MyZubster must provide a concrete architecture, TRL/maturity statement, implementation effort and IP/exploitation model.
- 7) At least one strong replication pathway should be secured; two are preferable.
- 8) Full budget and partner co-financing capacity must be checked before submission.

12. 10-DAY EXECUTION PLAN

Day 1–2 — Send/refresh partner outreach with this concept note; request 30-minute decision calls and a yes/no on consortium role.

Day 2–4 — Technical workshop with pilot/data owners: baseline, actual m³, data availability, parameters, SCADA/lab interfaces, reuse destinations, permits.

Day 3–5 — Scientific workshop: lock MRV/KPI/QA-QC methodology and identify exact WP4 lead.

Day 4–6 — Coordinator decision; collect PIC/legal details and administrative contacts.

Day 5–7 — Freeze consortium and draft one-page role/budget sheet per beneficiary.

Day 6–8 — Prepare Part B intervention logic, work packages, risks, deliverables and impact table.

Day 7–9 — Secure replication Lols and post-LIFE continuation/exploitation commitments.

Day 9–10 — Internal red-team against the four award criteria; remove unsupported claims and rebalance budget.

13. GO / NO-GO GATE

Proceed to full submission only if, within the next 7–10 days, we have at minimum:

- one credible coordinator;
- one confirmed infrastructure/pilot beneficiary or equivalent formal access commitment;
- one accountable scientific validator;
- written access/commitment covering the core baseline data;
- a budget/co-financing path compatible with the 60% maximum LIFE funding rate.

If any of the first three elements is missing, the project should not be presented as a mature demonstrator and the concept should be re-scoped rather than overclaimed.

14. OFFICIAL CALL FACTS USED FOR THIS WORKING NOTE

Call: LIFE-2026-SAP-ENV-ENVIRONMENT — Circular Economy and Zero Pollution.

Deadline: 22 September 2026, 17:00 CEST.

Topic budget: EUR 79 million; indicative project range EUR 2–10 million.

Submission: electronic only through Funding & Tenders Portal.

Maximum SAP funding rate: 60%.

Award criteria: Relevance, Impact, Quality, Resources; minimum 10/20 each; Impact weighting 1.5; overall weighted threshold 55.

15. NEXT DOCUMENTS TO PRODUCE AFTER PARTNER FEEDBACK

- 2-page external partner version of this concept note.
- Beneficiary role/budget fiches.
- Detailed WP/Gantt/deliverables/milestones table.
- KPI baseline-and-target evidence sheet.
- Data governance and architecture annex.
- Draft Letters of Intent.
- Funding & Tenders Part B master draft.